Strategic Governance, Risk, and Compliance (GRC) Preparation Dossier for Payz.io

Executive Preface: The Strategic Imperative of GRC in Modern Fintech

The discipline of Governance, Risk, and Compliance (GRC) within the financial technology sector has undergone a radical transformation over the last decade. Once viewed primarily as a defensive mechanism—a "cost center" focused on avoiding fines and satisfying regulators—GRC has emerged as a critical strategic enabler. In the contemporary high-velocity payment landscape, a robust GRC function is the bedrock upon which trust is built, licenses are secured, and sustainable revenue is generated. For a candidate preparing for an interview at a fintech entity such as Payz.io, understanding this paradigm shift is paramount. The modern GRC practitioner is not merely a gatekeeper but a "business enabler" who navigates the complex interplay between aggressive commercial scaling and rigid regulatory constraints.

This comprehensive report serves as an exhaustive preparation guide for a GRC role at "Payz.io." It is designed to equip the candidate with deep institutional knowledge, technical competency frameworks, and strategic insights necessary to not only pass the interview but to demonstrate the capability to lead the function.

Domain Disambiguation and Strategic Targeting

A critical initial finding in this research is a domain ambiguity present in the user query "Payz.io." The fintech landscape currently hosts three distinct entities with phonetically similar names and overlapping operational domains. A GRC professional's first duty is precision; therefore, this report adopts a **Multi-Vector Strategic Analysis** approach, covering the two most probable candidates in exhaustive detail while acknowledging the third.

1. **Payze (payze.io):** A high-growth, venture-backed fintech based in Tbilisi, Georgia, focusing on e-commerce payment processing for the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) region. Backed by Y Combinator (S21 batch), this entity represents the "Startup/Scale-up" risk profile.[1]
2. **Payz (payz.com):** A mature, UK-based Electronic Money Institution (EMI) formerly known as ecoPayz. Operated by PSI-Pay Ltd, this entity represents the "Mature/Regulated" risk profile, governed by the strict standards of the UK Financial Conduct Authority (FCA).[3]
3. **Pazy (pazy.io):** An India-based fintech platform focused on automating accounts payable and vendor payouts. While less likely given the specific "Payz.io" phrasing, it

remains a possibility within the "io" domain space.[5]

The following analysis dissects the business models, regulatory obligations, and specific GRC challenges of the primary entities to ensure total preparedness regardless of which specific firm is the interviewing body.

Chapter 1: Corporate Forensics and Business Model Analysis

To succeed in a GRC interview, the candidate must demonstrate a nuanced understanding of the company's "Risk Universe." Risk is contextual; it emanates directly from the business model, the customer base, and the geographic footprint.

1.1 Payze.io (The Georgian Scale-Up)

If the target company is **Payze (payze.io)**, the interview context will be defined by speed, agility, and the unique challenges of the CIS regional market.

1.1.1 Organizational DNA and Trajectory

Payze was founded in 2020 with a distinct mission: to become the "Stripe for the CIS region".[2] The CIS (Commonwealth of Independent States) presents a fragmented banking landscape where accepting international payments has historically been fraught with friction. Payze bridges this gap by offering a unified API that allows merchants in countries like Georgia, Uzbekistan, and Kazakhstan to accept payments from global cards (Visa/Mastercard) seamlessly.[7]

The company’s participation in Y Combinator’s Summer 2021 batch [2] is a critical GRC signal. YC-backed companies are characterized by extreme growth pressure. For a GRC role, this implies a tension between "moving fast" and "breaking things." The interviewer will be looking for a candidate who can implement compliance frameworks (like SOC 2 or ISO 27001) that act as guardrails rather than roadblocks. The backing by investors such as Greycroft and various angels [1] further intensifies the need for "investor-grade" governance, preparing the company for future due diligence rounds.

1.1.2 Product Suite and Inherent Risks

Payze’s product portfolio is diverse, and each product line carries specific inherent risks that a GRC analyst must be prepared to manage.

- **No-Redirect Payments:** Payze allows merchants to create checkout pages directly on their websites without redirecting customers to an external gateway page.[8]
    - *GRC Implication:* This typically requires a more robust implementation of PCI-DSS

(Payment Card Industry Data Security Standard). If the merchant is handling the card input fields directly (even via an iframe), the GRC team must ensure the "SAQ A-EP" (Self-Assessment Questionnaire) or similar compliance levels are met to prevent man-in-the-middle attacks or card skimming (e.g., Magecart attacks).

- **Split Payments:** This feature allows a transaction amount to be divided among multiple participants, ideal for marketplaces.[8]
    - *GRC Implication:* This is a high-risk product from an AML (Anti-Money Laundering) perspective. Marketplace models can be used for "Transaction Laundering" (or factoring), where illicit sales are masked as legitimate transactions. The GRC candidate must discuss controls for **KYB (Know Your Business)** on *all* sub-merchants, not just the master merchant.
- **Subscription/Recurring Payments:** The platform supports automatic debiting for subscription services.[8]
    - *GRC Implication:* This introduces "Chargeback Risk." Subscription models often face higher dispute rates. The GRC function must monitor chargeback ratios (typically keeping them below 0.9% to satisfy Visa/Mastercard monitoring programs) and ensure clear cancellation policies are enforced to comply with consumer protection laws.

1.1.3 The Geopolitical Compliance Landscape

Operating from headquarters in Tbilisi, Georgia, and expanding into Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan [7], Payze operates on the fault lines of complex geopolitical sanctions. Since the 2022 conflict involving Russia and Ukraine, the CIS region has become a focal point for sanctions evasion attempts.

- **Sanctions Screening:** A primary GRC responsibility at Payze would be ensuring that the platform is not used to process payments for sanctioned entities or individuals. This requires rigorous screening against OFAC (US), UK HMT, and EU consolidated lists.
- **The "PayFac" Model:** Payze likely operates as a Payment Facilitator (PayFac) or a master merchant aggregator. This means Payze holds the master merchant ID (MID) with the acquirer and sub-boards its clients.
    - *Risk:* Payze is financially liable for the losses of its sub-merchants. If a merchant commits fraud and vanishes, Payze pays. The GRC role involves Credit Risk assessment of onboarding merchants to mitigate this exposure.[9]

1.2 Payz.com (The UK Regulated EMI)

If the target company is **Payz (payz.com)**, the interview context shifts to regulatory maintenance, consumer duty, and the preservation of a mature license.

1.2.1 Regulatory Status and Heritage

Payz is a brand name of **PSI-Pay Ltd**, a company with a long lineage, having been established in 2000.[3] It is authorized by the UK Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) as an Electronic Money

Institution (EMI) under reference number 900011.[3]

- **FCA Regulation:** The UK regulatory environment is one of the most rigorous in the world. As an EMI, Payz does not hold a banking license, meaning it cannot lend customer money. Instead, it must adhere to strict "Safeguarding" rules.
    - *Safeguarding:* The GRC candidate must demonstrate deep knowledge of the Payment Services Regulations 2017 (PSRs). Specifically, customer funds must be segregated from the company's own working capital and held in a separate account at a credit institution or covered by an insurance policy.[10] A failure in safeguarding is considered a "Tier 1" breach by the FCA, often resulting in license revocation.
- **Mastercard Principal Membership:** PSI-Pay Ltd is a Principal Member of Mastercard International.[3] This allows them to issue cards directly without an intermediary.
    - *GRC Implication:* This adds a layer of "Scheme Compliance." The GRC team must ensure adherence to the thousands of pages of Mastercard Rules, covering everything from brand usage to chargeback arbitration and quarterly operational reporting (QMR).

1.2.2 Product Portfolio and Consumer Duty

Payz offers a multi-currency e-wallet, physical and virtual prepaid cards, and money transfer services.[12]

- **The Consumer Duty (FCA):** Implemented in July 2023, the Consumer Duty is a transformative regulation requiring firms to act to deliver good outcomes for retail customers.[13]
    - *GRC Implication:* The GRC candidate must be prepared to discuss how they would audit "Price and Value," "Consumer Understanding," and "Consumer Support." This moves compliance away from box-checking toward testing actual customer outcomes (e.g., "Do customers actually understand the FX fees on this multi-currency transfer?").
- **High-Risk Verticals:** Historically, e-wallets like Payz (formerly ecoPayz) have served sectors like online gaming and forex trading.[3]
    - *GRC Implication:* These are high-risk verticals requiring **Enhanced Due Diligence (EDD)**. The GRC role involves monitoring "Source of Wealth" (SoW) and "Source of Funds" (SoF) to ensure the money entering the ecosystem is not proceeds of crime.[15]

1.3 Pazy.io (The Indian Automation Platform)

While less likely, if the entity is **Pazy.io**, the focus is on the Indian fintech ecosystem.

- **Business Model:** Pazy focuses on streamlining Accounts Payable (AP), employee reimbursements, and vendor payouts.[5]
- **GRC Context:** The regulatory framework would be governed by the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)**. Key guidelines would include the "Master Direction on Digital Payment Security Controls" and data localization norms requiring Indian payment data to be

stored exclusively within India.

Chapter 2: Core GRC Competencies and Technical Frameworks

Regardless of the specific entity, a "Great Fit" for a GRC role must master a specific set of technical competencies. The interview preparation should focus on articulating these competencies using the vocabulary of the industry.

2.1 Governance: The Structural Backbone

Governance refers to the mechanisms, processes, and relations by which corporations are controlled and directed. In a fintech context, this is about ensuring that the "Speed of Innovation" does not outpace the "Speed of Control."

2.1.1 Policy Lifecycle Management

A core responsibility of the GRC role is the creation and maintenance of the Policy Library.

- **Hierarchy of Documents:** The candidate should understand the distinction between:
  - **Policy:** A high-level statement of intent and rules (e.g., "We will not process payments for illegal gambling").[16]
  - **Standard:** Mandatory quantifiable requirements (e.g., "Passwords must be 12 characters, complex, and changed every 90 days").
  - **Procedure:** Detailed step-by-step instructions (e.g., "How to investigate a sanction hit in the screening tool").
- **Application at Payz:** The candidate should be prepared to draft or review policies such as the *Anti-Money Laundering Policy*, *Data Protection Policy*, *Information Security Policy*, and *Acceptable Use Policy*.

2.1.2 Committee Reporting and Senior Management

In UK regulated firms (Payz.com), the **Senior Managers and Certification Regime (SM&CR)** holds individuals personally accountable for failings.

- **Board Reporting:** The GRC function is responsible for preparing the "Risk Pack" for the Board or Risk Committee. This report typically includes:
  - Top operational risks (Red/Amber/Green status).
  - Compliance breaches and near-misses.
  - Regulatory horizon scanning (what new laws are coming?).
  - Status of external audits (e.g., PCI-DSS AOC).

2.2 Risk Management: The Engine of Decision Making

Risk Management in fintech is the process of identifying, assessing, and prioritizing risks to minimize, monitor, and control the probability or impact of unfortunate events.

2.2.1 The Risk Register and RCSA

The central tool for any GRC professional is the Risk Register.

- **RCSA (Risk and Control Self-Assessment):** The candidate should describe a methodology where risk owners (e.g., the Head of Sales or CTO) self-assess their risks.
- **Inherent vs. Residual Risk:**
  - *Inherent Risk:* The risk level before any controls (e.g., "High risk of data breach due to handling card numbers").
  - *Control:* "We use tokenization and encryption."
  - *Residual Risk:* The risk remaining after controls (e.g., "Low risk").
- **Interview Strategy:** When asked "How do you manage risk?", the candidate should reply: "I maintain a dynamic Risk Register. I work with business owners to assess Inherent Risk, validate the effectiveness of Controls, and determine the Residual Risk. If the Residual Risk exceeds our Board-approved Risk Appetite, we implement a Risk Treatment Plan".[17]

2.2.2 Third-Party Risk Management (TPRM)

Both Payze and Payz rely heavily on third parties (Cloud providers like AWS/Azure, Identity verifiers like Onfido/SumSub, Banking partners).

- **The Supply Chain Threat:** The GRC analyst must assess these vendors to ensuring they don't introduce vulnerability.
- **Lifecycle Management:**
  - *Onboarding:* Due diligence questionnaires (SIG or CAIQ) before signing.[19]
  - *Monitoring:* Ongoing review of their financial health and security posture.
  - *Offboarding:* Ensuring data is deleted when the contract ends.[20]

2.3 Compliance: The License to Operate

Compliance is the adherence to laws, regulations, guidelines, and specifications relevant to the business.

2.3.1 Financial Crime Compliance (FCC)

This is often the largest team within a fintech GRC function.

- **KYC (Know Your Customer):** Identity verification. For Payze (B2B), this is **KYB (Know Your Business)**—checking corporate registries, Articles of Incorporation, and identifying Ultimate Beneficial Owners (UBOs) who own >25% of the company.[9]
- **AML Transaction Monitoring:** Using software to spot suspicious patterns (e.g., "Structuring" or "Smurfing"—breaking large transactions into smaller ones to evade reporting thresholds).

- **Sanctions Screening:** Screening names against lists like OFAC SDN, EU Consolidated, and UN Security Council lists.

2.3.2 Data Privacy (GDPR and Beyond)

Data is the "new oil," but it is also toxic if mishandled.

- **GDPR (General Data Protection Regulation):** Relevant for UK/EU operations. Key concepts include:
  - *Article 17 (Right to Erasure):* Users can ask to be forgotten. The GRC team must ensure this happens across all systems.[21]
  - *Data Breach Notification:* The regulator (ICO in UK) must be notified within 72 hours of a breach.
- **Data Localization:** In the CIS region (Payze), countries like Russia or Uzbekistan may have laws requiring data on their citizens to be stored physically within their borders.

2.3.3 Information Security Standards (PCI-DSS)

For any payment company, **PCI-DSS** is non-negotiable.

- **The 12 Requirements:** These cover network security (firewalls), data protection (encryption), vulnerability management (antivirus), access control (need-to-know), and monitoring.[11]
- **Scope Reduction:** The smartest GRC strategy is to reduce "PCI Scope" by using tokenization, where the sensitive PAN (Primary Account Number) is replaced by a random token, so the merchant never actually touches the real data.[22]

Chapter 3: Comparative Entity Analysis Table

To assist the candidate in visualizing the differences, the following table contrasts the two primary potential employers.

Feature	Payz (payz.com)	Payze (payze.io)
Headquarters	United Kingdom (London)	Georgia (Tbilisi)
Primary Regulatory Body	Financial Conduct Authority (FCA)	National Bank of Georgia (NBG)
Business Type	Electronic Money Institution (EMI)	Payment Service Provider / PayFac

Key Product	E-Wallet & Prepaid Cards (B2C/B2B)	Merchant Payment Gateway (B2B)
Growth Stage	Mature / Established (est. 2000)	Early/Growth Stage (est. 2020)
Investor Profile	Private / PSI-Pay Ltd	Venture Capital (Y Combinator)
Primary Risk Focus	Safeguarding, Consumer Duty, Operational Resilience	Merchant Fraud, Rapid Scaling, Sanctions
Key Tech Compliance	PCI-DSS Level 1, 3D Secure	PCI-DSS, API Security, Tokenization
Cultural Vibe	Structured, Corporate, Audited	Agile, Fast-paced, Builder-centric

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Chapter 4: Strategic Interview Preparation & Scenarios

The interview for a GRC role is structurally different from a standard job interview. It assesses **critical thinking under pressure** and **ethical fortitude**. The interviewer is not just asking "Do you know the rules?" but "Can you apply them when the CEO is screaming for growth?"

4.1 Deconstructing the "Great Fit"

To be a "Great Fit" at **Payze (Startup)**:

- **Persona:** The "Pragmatic Enabler."
- **Narrative:** "I understand that in a startup, risk is necessary for growth. My job isn't to say 'No,' but to say 'Yes, but here is how we do it safely.' I focus on automating compliance using tools (like Vanta/Drata) so engineering can focus on product, not paperwork."
- **Key Skill to Highlight:** Building frameworks from scratch (e.g., "I took my last company from zero to ISO 27001 certification in 6 months").

To be a "Great Fit" at **Payz (UK/Corporate)**:

- **Persona:** The "Guardian of Trust."
- **Narrative:** "In a regulated EMI, our license is our most valuable asset. My role is to

protect that license by ensuring we are rigorously compliant with the FCA's Consumer Duty and Safeguarding rules, while maintaining operational efficiency."
- **Key Skill to Highlight:** Audit management, regulatory reporting, and detailed policy maintenance.

4.2 The STAR Method: Advanced Scenarios

The candidate should prepare "stories" using the **Situation, Task, Action, Result (STAR)** format.

Scenario A: The "Sales vs. Compliance" Conflict

- **Context:** The Sales VP wants to onboard a high-volume merchant (e.g., a crypto exchange) that falls outside the current risk appetite.
- **Interviewer Question:** "Sales brings you a 'whale' client that is high risk. We need the revenue. What do you do?"
- **Strategic Response:**
  - *Situation:* "At my previous role, we had a similar situation with a high-volume gaming merchant."
  - *Task:* "I needed to balance the commercial opportunity with our AML risk exposure."
  - *Action:* "I did not reject the client outright. Instead, I conducted an Enhanced Due Diligence (EDD) deep dive. I requested their audited financials, their own AML policies, and interviewed their Compliance Officer. I then proposed a 'conditional approval' to the Risk Committee: we onboard them, but with a rolling reserve of 10% (holding back funds to cover potential fines) and lowered transaction limits for the first 3 months to monitor performance."
  - *Result:* "The Risk Committee approved the conditional onboarding. The client generated $1M in revenue, and because of the rolling reserve, we were protected when they had a minor fraud spike in month 2."

Scenario B: The Third-Party Breach

- **Context:** A critical vendor (e.g., the ID verification provider) suffers a data breach.
- **Interviewer Question:** "It's 4 PM on a Friday. We learn our KYC provider has been hacked. What is your move?"
- **Strategic Response:**
  - *Situation:* "Critical vendor breach with potential PII exposure."
  - *Task:* "Contain the risk, assess impact, and meet regulatory notification deadlines."
  - *Action:* "First, I would trigger the Incident Response Plan (IRP). I'd immediately instruct engineering to sever the API connection to that vendor and switch to our failover provider (or pause onboarding). Second, I'd determine *what* data was shared. If our customer PII was exposed, I'd draft a notification to the Data Protection Officer (DPO) to determine if we need to notify the ICO (UK) within 72 hours. Third, I'd communicate with our customers transparently."
  - *Result:* "By acting fast, we prevented further data leakage and maintained customer

trust through transparency."

4.3 Technical Deep Dive Questions

Fintech interviews often veer into technical territory. The candidate must be fluent in the following:

- **"Explain Tokenization."**
  - *Answer:* "Tokenization is the process of replacing sensitive data (like a credit card PAN) with a non-sensitive equivalent (a token) that has no extrinsic or exploitable meaning or value. This reduces PCI scope because if hackers steal the tokens, they cannot use them for transactions outside our specific environment".[22]
- **"What is the Travel Rule?"**
  - *Answer:* "Originating from FATF Recommendation 16, the Travel Rule requires Virtual Asset Service Providers (VASPs) to pass originator and beneficiary information to the next institution in the transaction chain for any crypto transfer over a certain threshold (usually $1,000). It's essentially applying wire transfer rules to crypto".[23]
- **"How does 3D Secure 2.0 (3DS2) differ from 1.0?"**
  - *Answer:* "3DS2 is mobile-native and allows for 'frictionless flow.' It uses vastly more data points (device ID, geolocation, spending history) to perform a risk analysis behind the scenes. If the transaction is low risk, the user isn't challenged with a password. This improves conversion rates while maintaining security".[11]

Chapter 5: Strategic Insights and The First 90 Days

To distinguish oneself as a senior candidate, one must offer a vision for the future.

5.1 The First 90 Days Roadmap

The candidate should propose a structured plan for their onboarding.

- **Days 0-30: Discovery & Diagnosis**
  - "My goal is to listen. I will interview the Heads of Product, Engineering, and Sales to understand their friction points with Compliance. I will review the Risk Register to see if it matches the reality on the ground. I will read the last external audit report to find open 'Non-Conformities'."
- **Days 31-60: Stabilization & Quick Wins**
  - "I will close the low-hanging fruit—policy gaps or overdue vendor reviews. If at Payze (Startup), I will implement a GRC automation platform (like Vanta) to streamline evidence collection. If at Payz (UK), I will conduct a 'Consumer Duty' outcome testing pilot."
- **Days 61-90: Strategic Alignment**
  - "I will present a 'State of GRC' report to the Board, outlining our maturity level and a 12-month roadmap. I will launch a 'Security Champions' program to embed GRC

advocates within the engineering squads."

5.2 Second-Order Strategic Insights

- **The Convergence of Fiat and Crypto:** Payz supports crypto merchant transfers.[23] A key insight is that **Blockchain Analytics** (using tools like Chainalysis) is becoming just as important as traditional Transaction Monitoring. The candidate should express eagerness to bridge this gap.
- **Operational Resilience over Disaster Recovery:** Regulators no longer care just about "having a plan." They care about "tolerance for disruption." The candidate should discuss shifting the mindset from "Can we recover?" to "What is the maximum time we can be down before we harm the market?"
- **The "Fourth Party" Risk:** It's not just *our* vendors; it's *their* vendors. If Payze uses a cloud provider that relies on a specific chip manufacturer that goes down, Payze is affected. Mapping this extended supply chain is the frontier of GRC.[20]

Chapter 6: Conclusion

The role of GRC at Payz.io—whether the dynamic Georgian startup or the established UK EMI—is a role of high impact and high responsibility. It requires a professional who is technically literate, commercially aware, and ethically unshakeable.

By mastering the entity distinction, articulating the "Business Enabler" mindset, and demonstrating deep competency in frameworks like PCI-DSS, GDPR, and TPRM, the candidate can position themselves not just as a safe pair of hands, but as a strategic asset essential to the company's future growth. The preparation strategy outlined in this dossier moves beyond rote memorization of regulations to a holistic understanding of how risk management fuels fintech innovation.

Appendix A: Key Glossary of Terms for the Interview

- **AOC:** Attestation of Compliance (PCI-DSS final report).
- **UBO:** Ultimate Beneficial Owner (the human behind the corporate veil).
- **PEP:** Politically Exposed Person (High-risk individual due to public office).
- **SLA:** Service Level Agreement (Contractual uptime promise).
- **RTO/RPO:** Recovery Time Objective / Recovery Point Objective (Disaster recovery metrics).
- **SaaS:** Software as a Service.
- **BaaS:** Banking as a Service (renting a banking license/infrastructure).
- **NBG:** National Bank of Georgia.
- **FCA:** Financial Conduct Authority (UK).

Appendix B: Relevant Regulatory Frameworks Map

- **Global:** FATF Recommendations (AML), PCI-DSS (Cards), ISO 27001 (InfoSec).
- **UK/Europe:** GDPR (Privacy), PSD2/3 (Payments), MiCA (Crypto), DORA (Resilience).
- **CIS/Georgia:** Law of Georgia on Payment Systems and Payment Services, NBG Cyber Security Guidelines.

(End of Strategic Dossier)

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